

Relationships are a vital internal need. When we look at what we value most, the 4 F's (faith, family, friends, and fulfilling work), each one of them is connected to relationships in some capacity. If 2020 and 2021 taught us anything, it's that we can survive long periods of isolation, but we function best in community. Yet sometimes we still avoid it.

People will opt to buy the brand-new lawn mower that sits in their shed most of the month instead of sharing with a neighbor. When an appliance breaks or our clothes lose a button, instead of learning from a friend how to fix it, we pay someone to fix it or buy its replacement. We'll even opt for online shopping over talking with a friend when it's been a rough day. Why is that?

One reason is that our culture highly values independence and self-reliance. Another is because we don't want to be a burden or "owe someone" later. Asking for help is seen as a power shift that we think another person doesn't want or will take advantage of. But these ways of thinking are costing us money, harm to the environment, and lack of connection.

When we can buy ourselves out of our problems, what happens to belonging, sharing, knowing, and supporting?

Imagine with me for a second an existence where you know those around you and you are known by them. You feel like the people around you are helping you become the best version of you and you're helping them do the same. There are shared resources—tangible and intangible, both tools and ideas! But you're not just taking, you're also giving. And every night you sing songs around a fire while holding hands. Just kidding about that last part. But I am trying to paint a picture of the benefits of community, the reciprocity that can happen in relationships, and the ripple effects these benefits can obviously have on all other aspects of our lives. Because curating our relationships is one of the ways we curate our external environment to support values-based spending.

A silver lining for me in the early days of the pandemic was parking our RV on Jen and Travis's property. In February 2020, we parked for what we thought would be six weeks, only to be unintentionally quarantined together for two months. We quickly learned the benefits of shared resources. With nowhere to go and nothing to do, it was a godsend to cook and spend evenings together. We combined what we had on hand, made up for what the other lacked, cooked meals, and enjoyed each other's company every